

ABITURPRÜFUNG 2024

zum Erwerb der fachgebundenen/allgemeinen Hochschulreife
an Fachoberschulen und Berufsoberschulen

ENGLISCH

Freitag, 17. Mai 2024

READING COMPREHENSION TEXTS

Diese Prüfung besteht aus zwei Teilen:

READING: Tasks I - III (9:00 bis 10:30 Uhr)

Pause von 30 Minuten

WRITING: Mediation D-E / Material-Based Writing (90 Minuten)

Im **READING**-Teil werden Texte und Aufgaben in zwei getrennten Geheften vorgelegt.

Die Aufgaben (**TASKS**) liegen in zwei Varianten (**V1** und **V2**) vor.

Diese sind gemischt auszugeben.

Alle Lösungen sind von den Prüflingen im Aufgabenteil einzutragen.

In der Pause werden die Text- und Aufgabengehefte von den Arbeitsplätzen der Schüler entfernt.

Der **WRITING**-Teil wird erst nach der Pause ausgegeben.

Hilfsmittel: Ein einsprachiges Wörterbuch (ggf. auch inkl. Writing Tutor)

Reading Text I: Conspiracy theories are festering in Britain – and our politicians are making it worse

(A) Over the past five years or so, one aspect of talking to the public about politics has become more and more pronounced. For a while, the conversations will largely be pretty straightforward, touching on politics and power, people's lives and the relationship – or lack of it – between them. And then, suddenly, somebody will tip the conversation into altogether more exotic territory, centred on a conspiracy theory. On a visit to Birmingham in 2022, I listened to two loquacious pensioners talking about how Covid-19 was a fiction invented by the world's rulers, and global death figures had largely been made up – opinions that blurred into a general sense that a lot of people still did not believe a word of what they had been told about the pandemic. The previous year, in fact, I had reported from parts of the city where community organisations were trying to get people to be vaccinated, in the face of large-scale public scepticism and hostility.

(B) Last week, there was a splurge of headlines about an opinion poll commissioned by the BBC. Its respondents were asked about a range of common conspiracy theories, from the idea that the pandemic was a hoax to the "great replacement" theory, whose advocates claim that white Europeans and Americans are deliberately being superseded by non-white migrants. The results were nothing if not consistent: for each of the stories, around 10% of people agreed that it was "definitely true", with another 20% or so ticking the box labelled "probably true". This latest research echoes other recent poll findings: in February, for example, the opinion platform UnHerd published polling data showing that 15% of people "strongly agree" with the contention that "the world is controlled by a secretive elite", with another 23% "mildly" agreeing. An overlooked point, it seems to me, is bound up with that second, softer category: it seems that the conspiracy hardcore's paranoid, hallucinatory view of the world now blurs into the beliefs held by a much bigger chunk of the population.

(C) Among most politicians and political observers, there is still precious little understanding of all this. They still tend to operate as if the vast majority of voters' views are much more orthodox: based on a latent leaning either left or right but essentially traditional, uncomplicated and understandable. What now pours into many people's social media feeds and out into the world, by contrast, is surely anything but. Everybody knows somebody who believes in shadowy cabals and covert global plots, and such people seem to form one part of a much wider range of opinions – united by a loathing of the political mainstream and a belief that all our institutions are irredeemably corrupt, commanded by invisible forces and beyond anyone's control. Self-evidently, a certain kind of politician will happily use the resulting soup of cynicism and delusion for their own purposes, and thereby make things even worse. In the US, Robert F Kennedy Jr – a challenger for the Democratic nomination, who has promoted conspiracy theories about the pandemic, gun ownership and a completely fictional link between vaccines and autism – is playing exactly that game.

(D) Boris Johnson, too, understands how to destabilise the political conversation by citing plots and conspiracies, a habit that will doubtless surface in his new column in the Daily Mail. When the letter announcing his resignation as an MP made reference to a “witch hunt ... to take revenge for Brexit and ultimately to reverse the 2016 referendum result”, it was yet another sign of that increasing Tory habit of inventing stories full of fear – ostensibly about such fantasies as the “woke blob”, but cast in the same basic language as much nastier ideas. The left, meanwhile, is not exactly blameless. A section of the enduring cult focused on Jeremy Corbyn¹ claims that his defeat was not the result of millions of former Labour voters walking away, but a conspiracy authored by the “Israel lobby” – the kind of antisemitic cliché that finds an echo at the other end of the political spectrum. On a bad day, it feels like our politics now consists of a centre once again full of dull technocrats, with, on either side, wild cultures of prejudice and paranoia, which add to the apparently growing number of voices claiming that the mundane business of democracy is nothing but a sham.

(E) Politicians who are focused on the comparatively dull stuff of policy and “delivery” will sooner or later have to at least talk about the sheer scale of 21st-century misinformation, and how it is twisting our politics. Doing so convincingly, however, will require traits that are currently in chronically short supply: an earthy, emotional approach to the job and a gift for the kind of storytelling that Johnson et al have put to the most obnoxious uses. There is also a very important conversation to be had about the kind of societies and economies our politicians want to create. Whenever I have talked to people who either believe in conspiracy theories or have soaked up their paranoid view of the world, they have tended to fit into two broad categories. **Some**, to be sure, **are hopelessly lost down online rabbit holes**. Other people’s beliefs, however, are often preceded by much more coherent stuff – about centres of power being hopelessly distant, corporate giants doing as they please and everyday life too often feeling fragile and meaningless. Take the first small steps to giving people a bit more security and certainty and the desperate appetite for conspiracy theory might start to die down, taking all those visions of microchips, faked figures and vampires with it.

John Harris, *The Guardian*, June 18, 2023 (930 words; adapted and abridged)

¹ Jeremy Corbyn: British politician who served as Leader of the Opposition and Leader of the Labour Party from 2015 to 2020.

Reading Text II: The AI apocalypse is coming! Personally, I welcome our new robot overlords

(A) What's the coolest apocalypse scenario? I'm quite partial to zombies myself, but that's probably because I was in university during the great zombie boom of the late 2000s, where it was impossible to engage with a piece of media that didn't have some kind of "zombie mode". Spending five years asking strangers in the smoking areas of pubs, "hey, how do you think you'd survive a zombie apocalypse?" is basically millennial navy seals training. This slow collapse of civilisation that we're living through right now is probably the least interesting version of Armageddon, so I'm pleased to report that it will soon be overtaken by my second-favourite doomsday scenario: the murder robots are coming.

(B) At least, that seems to be the case according to Geoffrey Hinton, a man so famous for his work in artificial intelligence that he's known as the "godfather of AI". Hinton recently left his job at Google, where he helped develop the underlying technology that paved the way for current AI systems such as ChatGPT. He has quit his job, ostensibly, to warn humanity about the dangers of AI. Hinton believes that in the short term, AI will be used to create a deluge of fake images, videos and text, which will leave the general public unable to distinguish between fact and fiction. Longer term, however, could be worse, as Hinton suggests the technology could lead to a future where robots surpass human intelligence, and ultimately decide to kill us off. Finally, some good news.

(C) I can't speak to the validity of Hinton's claims to the latter, but we should absolutely be concerned about the former. We were already struggling with "fake news" (i.e. shameless propaganda) before there were systems in place that could essentially automate it. Imagine how bad it's going to be when it's not just people tweeting fake information or dodgy news sites writing heavily biased or fabricated news articles, but fake pictures and videos that are indistinguishable from the real thing. Remember that picture that was going around a few weeks ago of the Pope in a big puffy rapper jacket? I thought that was real for two full days. Now, I'm very gullible, but at this rate this technology will be sophisticated enough to trick non-gullible people in no time at all.

(D) But what about his claims about a *Terminator*-style future where robots hunt us for sport? Honestly, as crazy as they might sound, nothing would really surprise me anymore. The rule for the past 10 years seems to have been: think of the worst, least likely thing that could possibly happen. I guarantee you, something even worse will end up happening. The funniest part of Hinton's statement is definitely the bit where he goes: "The idea that this stuff could actually get smarter than people – a few people believed that. But most people thought it was way off. And I thought it was way off. I thought it was 30 to 50 years or even longer away." Wait, experts like Hinton thought the AI doomsday scenario was only 30 years away, and **they ploughed ahead with it anyway?** 30 years isn't "way off"! That's no time! *Jurassic Park* came out 30 years ago!

(E) Hinton isn't even the only AI expert that believes the technology they helped create will eventually destroy us. In a recent podcast appearance, Paul Christiano, who ran the language model alignment team at OpenAI, said he takes "quite seriously" the idea that artificial intelligence will enslave and ultimately destroy humanity. So what's the solution? Do we outlaw AI? Do we pass a bunch of laws to try and regulate it? That doesn't seem likely, since our policymakers still haven't figured out a way to stop neo-Nazis from recruiting on Twitter, or organising hate campaigns against individuals they disagree with. We'll be hiding from Skynet while the government is still trying to figure out whether or not unplugging the AssassinBot 3000 is a violation of its right to free speech.

(F) What I do know is this: whether or not we get a viscerally satisfying apocalypse out of this, with cyber tanks and sentient laser turrets, the much greater threat in the short term is to the labour market. This is something that Hinton touches on, but it's probably the thing that is likely to affect you, the reader, most. It's certainly going to affect me. I don't think I would have bothered putting all my energy into a writing career if I'd known that people put so little value into the quality of the texts they consume that they'll happily outsource that work to an AI language model. You might think you're safe, but if you work in a field that can be handed over to an algorithm, rest assured that it eventually will be. AI doesn't take smoke breaks, it doesn't sexually harass its co-workers, and the only compensation it requires is your sweet, sweet information. For now, the issue whether or not the robots are coming to harvest your weak, human, fleshy organs is irrelevant. They're definitely coming for your jobs.

Ryan Coogan, *The Independent*, May 3, 2023 (843 words; adapted and abridged)

Reading Text III: The Underground Railroad

“The Underground Railroad” is a 2016 novel by Colson Whitehead. It is set in mid-19th century America, when slavery was still legal in the South. The following excerpt is about an argument between two African American leaders (Mingo and Lander) of the so-called Valentine Farm, a fictional 1850s black settlement in Indiana.

“We accomplished the impossible,” Mingo said, “but not everyone has the character we do. We’re not all going to make it. **Gap 1** Slavery has twisted their minds, an imp filling their minds with foul ideas. They have given themselves over to whiskey and its false comforts. **Gap 2** You’ve seen these lost ones on the plantations, on the streets of the towns and cities – those who will not, cannot respect themselves. You’ve seen them here, receiving the gift of this place but unable to fit in. They always disappear in the night because deep in their hearts they know they are unworthy. It is too late for them. There are realities we have to face,” Mingo explained. “White people aren’t going to change overnight. The farm’s dreams are worthy and true, but require a gradual approach. We can’t save everyone, and acting as if we can will doom us all. You think the white folks – just a few miles from here – are going to endure our impudence forever? We flaunt their weakness. Harboring runaways. Underground railroad agents² with guns coming and going. **Gap 3** Criminals.” The Valentine farm had taken glorious steps into the future, he said. White benefactors supplied schoolbooks for their children – why not ask them to pass the hat for entire schools? And not just one or two, but dozens more? By proving the negro’s thrift and intelligence, Mingo argued, he will enter into the American society as a productive member with full rights. Why jeopardize that? We need to slow things down. Reach an accommodation with our neighbors and, most of all, stop activities that will force the wrath upon us. “We’ve built something astounding here”, he concluded. “But it is a precious thing, and it needs to be protected, nourished, or else it will wither, like a rose in a sudden frost.” (...)

“Brother Mingo made some good points,” Lander said. “We can’t save everyone. But that doesn’t mean we can’t try. **Gap 4** Nothing’s going to grow in this mean cold, but we can still have flowers. Here’s one delusion: that we can escape slavery. We can’t. Its scars will never fade. When you saw your mother sold off, your father beaten, your sister abused by some boss or master, did you ever think you would sit here today, without chains, without the yoke, among a new family? Everything you ever knew told you that freedom was a trick – yet here you are. Still we run, tracking by the good full moon to sanctuary. Valentine farm is a delusion. Who told you the negro deserved a place of refuge? Who told you that you had that right? Every minute of your life’s suffering has argued otherwise. By every fact of history, it can’t exist. This place must be a delusion, too. Yet here we are. And America, too, is a delusion, the grandest one of all. The white race believes – believes with all its heart – that it is their right to take the land. To kill Indians.

² During the era of slavery, the Underground Railroad was a network of routes, places, and people that helped enslaved people in the American South escape to the North.

Make war. Enslave their brothers. This nation shouldn't exist, if there is any justice in the world, for its foundations are murder, theft, and cruelty. Yet here we are.

I'm supposed to answer Mingo's call for gradual progress, for closing our doors to those in need. I'm supposed to answer those who think this place is too close to the grievous influence of slavery, and that we should move west. I don't have an answer for you. I don't know what we should do. The word *we*. In some ways, the only thing we have in common is the color of our skin. Our ancestors came from all over the African continent. It's quite large. They had different ways of subsistence, different customs, spoke a hundred different languages. And that great mixture was brought to America in the holds of slave ships. To the north, the south. Their sons and daughters picked tobacco, cultivated cotton, worked on the largest estates and smallest farms. We are craftsmen and midwives and preachers and peddlers. Black hands built the White House, the seat of our nation's government. The word *we*. **Gap 5** How can one person speak for this great, beautiful race – which is not one race but many, with a million desires and hopes and wishes for ourselves and our children? For we are Africans in America. Something new in the history of the world, without models for what we will become. **Color must suffice**. It has brought us to this night, this discussion, and it will take us into the future. All I truly know is that we rise and fall as one, one colored family living next door to one white family. We may not know the way through the forest, but we can pick each other up when we fall, and we will arrive together."

When the former residents of the Valentine farm recalled that moment, when they told strangers and grandchildren of how they used to live and how it came to an end, their voices still trembled years later. In Philadelphia, in San Francisco, in the cow towns and ranches where they eventually made a home, they mourned those who died that day. The air in the room turned prickly, they told their families, quickened by an unseen power. (...)

The shot hit Lander in the chest. He fell back, dragging down the lectern. Three bullets bit into the back of the man who ran to help him. He jerked like one of Saint Vitus's dancers and dropped. Then came a chorus of rifle fire, screams, and broken glass, and a mad scramble overtook the meeting hall. **Gap 6**

Colson Whitehead, *The Underground Railroad*, London, 2016, pp. 338-343. (936 words, abridged and adapted)